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Rahab

The Canaanite woman of Jericho who hid Israel's spies and was saved by faith.

Rahab lived in Jericho, the first city Israel faced across the Jordan. Scripture calls her a harlot, and her house was built into the city wall. When Joshua sent two spies into the city, she hid them on her roof and sent the king's men the wrong way. She had heard what the LORD had done for Israel, and she confessed that he is God in heaven above and in earth beneath. She asked for mercy for her family, and the spies gave her a sign: a scarlet cord in her window. When Jericho fell, she and her household were spared. The New Testament names her among the heroes of faith and in the family line of Jesus.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Rachav</i> , usually explained as "broad" or "wide"
People	A Canaanite of Jericho
Known as	"Rahab the harlot" (Joshua 6:17; Hebrews 11:31; James 2:25)
When	The fall of Jericho, c. 1406 BC (late-date view c. 1220 BC)
Key places	Jericho; her house on the town wall (Joshua 2:15)
Key people	The two spies, Joshua, her father's household
Main passages	Joshua 2:1–24; 6:17, 22–25
New Testament	Matthew 1:5 ("Rachab"); Hebrews 11:31; James 2:25

"By faith the harlot Rahab perished not with them that believed not, when she had received the spies with peace."

Hebrews 11:31, KJV

The life of Rahab

Dates follow the early date of the Exodus. On the late date, Jericho falls c. 1220 BC. Scripture gives no age for Rahab.

- c. 1406 BC

In Jericho

● Hears the news

Word reaches Jericho of the Red Sea and of Israel's victory over Sihon and Og. The people's hearts melt with fear. *Joshua 2:9-11*
- c. 1406 BC

On her roof

● Hides the spies

Two men sent by Joshua lodge at her house. She hides them under stalks of flax and tells the king's men they have already gone. *Joshua 2:1-7*
- c. 1406 BC

At the window

● Makes a pact

She confesses faith in the LORD and asks for her family's lives. She lets the spies down by a cord, and they tell her to tie a scarlet line in the window. *Joshua 2:8-21*
- c. 1406 BC

When Jericho falls

● Saved

Joshua orders that she be spared. The two spies bring out Rahab, her parents, her brothers and all she has. *Joshua 6:17, 22-23*
- Afterward

● Lives in Israel

She and her family are settled outside the camp at first. The writer adds that she "dwelleth in Israel even unto this day." *Joshua 6:23, 25*

Group notes

Key activities

Some ancient writers, including Josephus, called Rahab an innkeeper. The Hebrew word and the New Testament both call her a harlot. Christians also differ on how to judge her lie to the king's men: some see it as wrong but forgiven, others as a lesser wrong to protect life.

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- 1 Welcomed the spies.** She took them into her house and hid them on the roof. *Joshua 2:1-6*
 - 2 Misled the king's men.** She sent the searchers toward the Jordan while the spies were still hidden. *Joshua 2:3-7*
 - 3 Confessed the LORD.** She said, "for the LORD your God, he is God in heaven above, and in earth beneath." *Joshua 2:11*
 - 4 Asked for mercy.** She asked for a "true token" that her father's house would be spared. *Joshua 2:12-14*
 - 5 Helped them escape.** She let them down through the window and told them to hide in the mountain three days. *Joshua 2:15-16, 22*
 - 6 Kept the sign.** She tied the scarlet line in the window and gathered her family inside. *Joshua 2:18-21; 6:22-23*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Rahab.

Old Testament

Joshua 2:1–24	She hides the spies and makes a pact with them
Joshua 6:17, 22–25	She and her household are spared
Echo: Exodus 12:13, 22–23	Blood on the doorposts marks the saved houses
Echo: Ruth 1:16	Another foreign woman chooses Israel's God

New Testament

Matthew 1:5	"Salmon begat Booz of Rachab"; most take her as Boaz's mother, though the time gap is debated
Hebrews 11:31	Named among the heroes of faith
James 2:25	"Justified by works, when she had received the messengers"
Echo: Matthew 21:31–32	Harlots enter the kingdom before the leaders
Tradition	Clement of Rome saw the scarlet cord as a picture of Christ's blood

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What had Rahab heard about Israel's God, and what did she conclude (Joshua 2:9–11)?
2. *Understand:* Hebrews praises her faith and James her works. Why does her story fit both?
3. *Apply:* Rahab's past did not keep her out of God's people. How should we welcome others?
4. *Apply:* Rahab acted on her belief at real risk. What step of faith could you take this week?